Once more, we had reason to be hopeful about the future of the Middle East. Then Syria, apparently emboldened by its new late-model Russian arms and thousands of new Soviet “advisors,” began sending signals that *it* would not leave Lebanon. This meant that the hard-won agreement between Lebanon and Israel couldn’t be implemented, either.

Once again, we called on Jordan and Saudi Arabia, which had good reason to be worried about the growing Soviet presence in Syria as a serious threat to their oilfields, to apply pressure on Syria to leave. I reassured a nervous President Gemayel that we would keep our marines in Lebanon and not abandon his country while we tried to work out a settlement.

George Shultz went back to Lebanon to see if he could accelerate the departure of Syria, but, disappointingly, he found that the Arab world was badly fractured and either unable or unwilling to exert the necessary leverage to get Syria out of Lebanon. He and Robert C. (Bud) McFarlane of the National Security Council, who had taken over Habib’s responsibilities as special envoy to the Middle East, tried hard through the summer and early fall of 1983 to persuade Syria to agree to leave, but the situation deteriorated steadily. The Syrian and Israeli forces remained entrenched, while old feuds between Lebanese Christians and Muslims began to erupt in an increasingly bitter civil war.

Meanwhile, new problems surfaced in the Middle East. Apparently deciding to move while much of the world was distracted by events in Lebanon, the region’s foremost terrorist, Libya’s Muammar Qaddafi—like Syria’s president, Hafez al-Assad, a client of Moscow—began making new moves on two of his neighbors in North Africa, Sudan and Chad. France, the former colonial ruler of Chad, sent in troops to fight against the Libyan-backed rebels, and at